

Who Reads What, in Which Formats, and Why?

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Who is reading what seems like a straightforward question. Answers, however, are surprisingly difficult to pin down, being short-term in nature, frequently provisional in their warrant, and very often contradictory.

The bound paper book is not dead yet, as we will see; the contemporary picture is complex. The codex culture was relatively easy to enumerate. Bestseller lists have their limitations (they silently elide the true bestsellers, the Bibles, cookbooks, and dictionaries, for example), but they offer something like a specific tally, with numbers attached. Circulation figures for newspapers and magazines are reassuringly concrete. But that era has vanished.

This chapter begins with the watershed summer of 2016 and uses the developments of that season to set up categories for discussing a complex and fast-moving scenario. In Part I, “What is going on?,” a brief outline of that summer’s developments under five headings is expanded into a broader exploration of each of these topics. Part II, “Why it matters,” discusses the importance of choice and its implications for achievement. Part III, “How we assess it,” looks at the difficulties of assembling and assessing evidence in the volatile conditions of contemporary literacy choices. Finally, Part IV, “How we read what we read in the 21st century,” investigates the implications of our new cultural arrangements for forms of social, deep, and critical reading.

Part I: What Is Going On? Five Snapshots of a Complicated World

A brief overview of a single season, summer 2016, provides a small case study of the complexities of what people read, on what platforms, and for what purposes. It was a lively season that raised many questions about possible directions for a reading culture. I first present the highlights of that summer and then discuss subsequent trends and movements in more detail.

- The summer of 2016 was dominated by two texts, neither of them a conventional novel: the augmented reality (AR) app game, *Pokémon GO*, and the script of a stage play, *Harry Potter and the Cursed Child* (Rowling, Tiffany, & Thorne, 2016). Each of these titles, of course, is part of a much larger textual universe; and they represent a striking component of contemporary life: reading is frequently entwined with a host of related texts, and written texts form just one element of a franchise of related titles crossing media boundaries.

- The summer of 2016 represented a turning point (at least for the moment) in how we assess the impact of e-books and e-reading. A steady rise in the percentage of readers using electronic platforms was turned back in 2016; though e-reading remains important, it is no longer advancing so steadily.
- The billionth iPhone was sold in the summer of 2016. Smartphones and tablet computers represent a breakthrough in portability, being as mobile and easy to carry as a book, a fact with many disruptive consequences that are still being assessed.
- The summer of 2016 marked the 25th anniversary of the World Wide Web, which caused its own kind of reading revolution – particularly, but not exclusively, with regard to information seeking behaviours.
- The exploitation of algorithms on social media was already a concern in 2016. This last topic, of course, has only increased in significance since we now have reason to question the impact of the “harvesting” of social media data on at least two major events of 2016: the Brexit vote in the United Kingdom, and the Presidential election in the United States.

All these glimpses of a cultural scene in flux offer only snapshots of a fast-moving scenario. Looking back today, however, it seems clear that each of these five pointers represents a significant shift in reading behaviours. What can we learn from an expanded view of each topic?

- Franchises play an important role in recruiting reader interest and participation.

Two blockbusters, in different formats, dominated media news of summer 2016. *Pokémon GO* was an Augmented Reality app game, and *Harry Potter and the Cursed Child* was a print book of a playscript, featuring a new Harry Potter story by J. K. Rowling. The Harry Potter playscript sold two million copies in North America within two days of its launch (www.hollywoodreporter.com/news/harry-potter-cursed-child-script-916817). The distribution of *Pokémon GO* reached 100 million downloads worldwide in a matter of weeks (<http://expandedramblings.com/index.php/pokemon-go-statistics/>). Ypulse, a youth marketing research group, found that American 13–33-year-olds, in August 2016, cited *Pokémon Go* as their favourite app, beating out (in order) Snapchat, Facebook, Instagram, Spotify, YouTube, Twitter, Pinterest, Tumblr, and Facebook Messenger, to rule the Top Ten (www.ypulse.com/post/view/millennials-teens-15-favorite-apps-right-now).

A year after its release, in June 2017, *Pokémon Go* was still attracting 60 million monthly users (compared to 100 million at its peak, the previous August). Total revenues stood at \$1.2 billion, with 752 million downloads (Minotti, 2017, n.p.) Similarly, the Harry Potter franchise remained dominant. *Harry Potter and the Cursed Child* was the runaway number one title of 2016, selling 4.1 million copies; for comparison, *The Girl on the Train*, the number two title for that year according to *Fortune*, sold 836,000 copies (<http://fortune.com/2017/06/26/harry-potter-20th-anniversary/>). In 2018, the Pottermore website reported sales of half a billion copies of Harry Potter (the seven books of the series and the three companion volumes), cumulating from the publication of the first book in 1997. Audiobook versions add to the numbers: the Pottermore news team said on February 1, 2018, that “more than 4 billion Harry Potter minutes” have been consumed in audiobook form since 2016. The books have been translated into more than 80 languages. Overall, and on average, “this means one in fifteen people in the world owns a Harry Potter book” (<https://www.pottermore.com/news/500-million-harry-potter-books-have-now-been-sold-worldwide>, 2018).

It is difficult to think of two larger text universes than *Pokémon* and *Harry Potter*. They represent many different kinds of reading experiences – the taxonomic precision of the Pokémon collector’s guidebook or the rules for the games is a sharp contrast to the multi-volume expansiveness of Rowling’s

narrative fiction, which was reshaped further for movies and videogames. Entering these worlds through words is only one part of the experience, and readers who engage with them do not feel that this reading is a stand-alone encounter. Reading as only one fraction of a broader story experience is now a commonplace occurrence of our culture.

- Any account of book reading habits and access now must include information about format as well as content – and venue also matters.

In the early part of the decade, e-reading increased from 17% of American adults reporting they had read an e-book in 2011 all the way up to 28% in 2016, according to findings from the Pew Research Center (Perrin, 2016). But 2016 seems to represent the peak for e-reading, at least for the moment. A January 2018 survey found a dip to 26%. Meanwhile, the slippage of those reporting reading a paper book (from 71% in 2011 to as low as 63% in 2015) began to level out in 2016, and by 2018 had climbed back to 67%. But these two categories do not exhaust the possibilities; an increasing number of American adults listen to audiobooks. The percentage rises from 11% in 2011 to 18% in 2018 – nearly one in five (Perrin, 2018). Altogether 74% of Americans have read a book in any format over the past twelve months prior to January 2018 (Perrin, 2018).

Access to reading material is not a politically neutral issue. The publishing industry in English-speaking countries is still very white, both in terms of personnel and also in terms of product. “We Need Diverse Books” is a campaign that aims to broaden the range and appeal of what is made available to young people (<https://diversebooks.org>); one point that seems very clear is that readers cannot acquire what does not exist. At a different level of access, the threat to public libraries in the United Kingdom, for example, where many libraries are shutting to save taxpayer’s money, or being turned over to volunteers for the same reason, has raised widespread alarm that is not just confined to that country. For a quick overview of the situation, a newspaper article by the chair of The Library Campaign sums up some of the chaos that currently swamps library planning in the U.K. (Swaffield, 2017). School libraries are also part of an ongoing political argument. Again in the U.K., a new three-year campaign hopes to make the provision of a school library a statutory requirement (Allen-Kinross, 2018); but this dispute is not just a British one. The issue of bookstores in many different countries is also a complicated one, featuring an uneven playing field on which independent bookstores, big box corporate chains, and the online behemoth of Amazon, all compete for the attention of book buyers; Nobel (2017) offers a brief history of some of this battle in the United States.

- Smartphones and tablet computers represent a disruptive force.

The textual world of the digital, with all its interactive and multimodal potential, is now as mobile and portable as a book. In July 2016, Apple announced the sale of its billionth iPhone, since the initial launch of 2007 (www.statista.com/chart/5390/cumulative-iphone-sales/). The iPad was also astonishingly successful, selling 308 million between its launch in April 2010 and March 2016 (<http://ipod.about.com/od/ipadmodelsandterms/f/ipad-sales-to-date.htm>). The sales numbers for Apple’s competitors must also be factored in, and the overall totals mark a key change in reading access.

Mobile phones are increasingly ubiquitous, and not just in the developed West. Two-thirds of the 7.6 billion people in the world now have a mobile phone, and more than half of the handsets in use today are smartphones (Kemp, 2018, n.p.). Young people are particularly apt to use them on an ongoing basis, as eMarketer reported in late 2017:

According to the survey, which polled 2,000 US internet users ages 18 to 75, most people check their device approximately 47 times per day. And younger users? Well, they tend to check it with a significantly higher frequency – roughly 86 times a day. That’s an increase from the 82 times per day reported in 2016.

(<https://www.emarketer.com/Article/Obsessed-Much-Mobile-Addiction-Real/101November16,6759>, 2017)

The rise of smartphones enables a variety of textual activities. Ypulse surveyed 1000 13–33-year-old Americans, 80% of whom owned a smartphone, and reported in 2016 that their daily activities include messaging first and foremost, followed by social networking (www.ypulse.com/post/view/what-millennials-teens-are-doing-on-their-smartphones-every-single-day1).

These young people are reading across a variety of modalities as part of their regular daily activities, and frequently encountering what this report calls “snackable content” (n.p.).

But even as access to the Internet expands exponentially, not all reading comes in “snack” size. Book reading continues to be important, though to different degrees in different countries, and mobile phones are the portal to long-form reading in many places. A UNESCO report comments on this trend:

Why mobile phones? Because people have them. ... Collectively, mobile devices are the most ubiquitous information and communication technology (ICT) in history. More to the point, they are plentiful in places where books are scarce.

(UNESCO, 2014, 16)

The UNESCO report, of course, is considering the advantages of mobile reading in situations where access to paper reading is very limited. Merga and Roni (2017) point out that we need to know much more about the advantages and drawbacks of e-reading in comparison to paper reading, and suggest that the virtues of the electronic space are not quite so clear-cut in circumstances where more choice is possible. Their survey of nearly a thousand young Australians (in Year 4 and Year 6) indicates that “access to eReading devices does not appear to increase reading frequency and in the case of mobile phone access, may in fact be associated with infrequency” (195). They suggest that schools and libraries should establish a clearer understanding of child preferences before making substantial conversions away from paper and towards digital books.

- The World Wide Web turned 25 in the summer of 2016.

A report in early 2018 reveals that more than 4 billion people around the world are using the Internet:

Well over half of the world’s population is now online, with the latest data showing that nearly *a quarter of a billion* new users came online for the first time in 2017. Africa has seen the fastest growth rates, with the number of internet users across the continent increasing by more than 20% year-on-year.

(Kemp, 2018, n.p.)

These rapid increases in access are not neutral, however; in mid-2018, Sambuli reported that the African digital divide is gender-based: “Just 22% of Africa’s citizens are online and the continent has the widest gender gap in connectivity” (n.p.).

How people make use of their online access is perhaps a more complex question. In September 2016, Google introduced Penguin 4.0, a new version of its algorithm for filtering search

results (<https://webmasters.googleblog.com/2016/09/penguin-is-now-part-of-our-core.html>). That year, a British survey by Ofcom (2016), of adults' media use and attitudes, established that 62% of users thought that a Google search would return some reliable websites and some that were not trustworthy. 18% (nearly one in five) thought that if the search engine returned a result, the listed websites would offer accurate and unbiased information. Respondents were shown a screenshot of results of a Google search for "walking boots." The first three results were "distinguished by an orange box with the word 'Ad' written on it" (150). They were prompted to comment on whether these first three results were advertisements/sponsored links, or were the best/most relevant results, or were the most popular results. 60% correctly identified the entries as advertisements; 23% thought they represented the best or most relevant results, and 20% considered them to be the most popular. Clearly there is room for improved information literacy in such a scenario.

But children do not turn first to Google, according to David Kleeman, who is quoted in Howard's (2016) analysis of children's media preferences:

today's children use YouTube as Google because when they're curious about something, they don't want text: they want images, sound, and/or video ... YouTube is one of the most influential factors on children, second only to their friends.

(2016, n.p.)

Readily available access to information that does not require reading marks a significant point of change in children's textual experience.

- The exploitation of algorithms on social media was already a concern in 2016.

Herrman (2016) and Tynan (2016) separately describe organizations explicitly designing political content in order to exploit Facebook's algorithms for news story promotion. Herrman describes the impact of this material as "gigantic," with cumulative audiences of tens of millions of people. He calls these specialist sites "perhaps, the purest expression of Facebook's design and of the incentives coded into its algorithm – a system that has already reshaped the web and has now inherited, for better or for worse, a great deal of America's political discourse" (n.p.).

These 2016 commentaries were prescient of scandal to come. The 2018 public perspective on Facebook's algorithms is more broadly distrustful, and it remains to be seen if the company can recover from revelations that the data of 87 million Facebook users were improperly "harvested" and exploited by the British consulting company Cambridge Analytica, with effects on assorted elections that are yet to be fully determined.

Part II: Why It Matters: The Role of Reading Choice

What people choose to read is a vitally important element of the reading experience. Choice of reading materials links to reading pleasure, and studies from many countries attest that reading pleasure correlates with reading achievement (Cullinan, 2000; Education Standards Research Team, 2012; Meiers, 2004; Sullivan & Brown, 2015).

Perhaps the most substantial international figures on both young people's achievements and their attitudes to reading come from PISA, the Programme for International Student Assessment, organized by the Organization for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD). PISA conducts large-scale international assessments of 15-year-olds around the globe and issues many influential comparative tables. The most recent 2015 results (OECD, 2016) show the largest number of countries holding steady, rather than marking improvement:

Of the 64 countries and economies with comparable data in reading performance, 20 show a positive trend in mean reading performance across the most recent PISA assessments, 31 show a stable trend, and the remaining 13 countries and economies show a deteriorating trend in average student performance.

(OECD, 2016, 152)

Much national commentary focuses obsessively and unhelpfully on the “league table” elements of the PISA results, but by themselves they represent only a single snapshot. PISA investigates achievement in mathematics and science as well, and rotates a deeper look between these three subject areas. Reading was last explored in depth in 2009 (it is due for another special investigation in 2018); and these broader findings offer subtler insight into the state of reading than the comparative and competitive statistics. About two-thirds of the students reporting in 2009 say that they read for pleasure on a daily basis, but that number is unevenly distributed. “On average across OECD countries, 72% of socio-economically advantaged students... reported that they read daily for enjoyment while only 56% of disadvantaged students reported doing the same” (OECD, 2011, 2). PISA also reports that reading daily for enjoyment, had a stronger correlation with reading achievement than the amount of time students spend reading. The trend between 2000 and 2009, however, was downwards, especially among boys; PISA reported that the percentage of students reading daily for enjoyment dropped, on average, from 69% to 64%. Twenty-two countries saw the number drop, but ten reported an increase (OECD, 2011, 2–3).

Domestic access to books also connects to academic achievement; M. D. R. Evans and collaborators investigated the connection between book ownership at home and education, first in 27 countries (2010), and later in 42 countries (2014). Ownership of even a modest number of books at home correlates with more years of schooling, even after taking account of other contributing factors.

But an understanding of what people are reading is no longer simply a case of tallying decisions about book selection and ownership. The issue of who is reading what, has probably never included more diverse materials. Much academic research to date has considered the impact of books on reading success. We know less about the implications of access to other forms of text, though a suggestive study in India discovered that “time spent on the computer and internet was consistently and positively associated with academic achievement, while television viewing, regardless of content viewed, was negatively associated” (Malhi, Bharti, & Sidhu, 2016, 73). An OECD report on the PISA findings of 2015 said, “Between 2012 and 2015, the time that 15-year-olds reported spending on the Internet increased from 21 to 29 hours per week, on average across OECD countries” (2018, 2). But too much time on the Internet correlates with poorer achievement in science. Moderate Internet usage correlates with higher achievement (2018, 4–5). We simply do not yet know if and/or how the advantage of access to books translates to access to interactive screens.

UNESCO is confident that mobile screen reading represents a breakthrough in the pursuit of global literacy:

Among other conclusions, UNESCO has learned that people read more when they read on mobile devices, that they enjoy reading more, and that people commonly read books and stories to children from mobile devices. The study shows that mobile reading represents a promising, if still underutilized, pathway to text. It is not hyperbole to suggest that if every person on the planet understood that his or her mobile phone could be transformed – easily and cheaply – into a library brimming with books, access to text would cease to be such a daunting hurdle to literacy.

(UNESCO, 2014, 17)

Reading on a mobile phone may link more easily to other media forms such as sound and moving images. Of course, reading has never been purely verbal. Design and layout have always contributed to meaning, and context has always framed interpretation. Today, however, words on a page or screen may be part of a much more multimodal array:

The increasingly multimodal ecosystem through which we filter news, social networks, and both visual and textual entertainment makes *reading* a much slipperier term than ever before. ... What is a text, and how do you read it? are two questions that are increasingly in flux today.

(Garcia, 2016, 95)

Some people's reading is closely implicated with other activities. Much videogame-playing, for example, calls for a great deal of conventional reading and writing (Steinkuehler, 2007). Gamers also produce reading material for each other; for example, the knowledge production by players for players in relation to a massive online game such as *World of Warcraft* is remarkable. In early 2018, the WOWWiki boasted 298,252 pages of content much of it created by players (<http://wowwiki.wikia.com/wiki/Portal:Main>); and a breakaway site, WOWpedia, is also enormous, though no figures were readily available (<https://wow.gamepedia.com/Portal:Main>). For younger readers, *Minecraft* offers a similar gateway to numerous reading activities (Italie, 2014; Maughan, 2015; Revoir, 2016). Game-related reading (and writing) may occur within the diegetic story world or in a larger zone of strategic decision-making. In related ways, fan collectives turn an original reading experience into a panoply of further reading, writing, and responding.

With such a range of options, young people are almost certainly learning to take multimodality very much for granted as part of their reading lives. There is much we need to learn about how families select the materials they load onto their screens. A child who regularly visits a library full of paper books will choose from a huge array of possibilities; in contrast, even to find out that a particular electronic text exists may involve complex browsing and searching skills (Vaala, Ly, & Levine, 2015). The alternative may be simply to download an uncritical sample of whatever turns up at the top of the charts in the app store.

But choice remains important. Ming Ming Chiu and Catherine McBride-Chang (2006) demonstrate the powerful impact of that autonomous power to select. They conducted an analysis of students in 43 countries, basing their work on the 2002 instantiation of the PISA findings (338). Their massive data set came from a pool of 193,841 15-year-old students. Their main points are as follows:

In every country, girls outscored boys in reading. The explanatory model further showed that gender, log GDP per capita [a statistical refinement of growth measurement], family SES [socio-economic status], schoolmates' SES, number of books at home, and reading enjoyment were all significantly associated with reading score. *Only reading enjoyment mediated the gender effect.*

(2006, 343, *emphasis added*)

Reading enjoyment relates directly to *what* is being read, and is clearly a potent factor, across very large numbers of teens in a wide range of countries. Other age ranges also benefit from the ability to choose; adults often take it for granted, but the role of autonomous selection in reading pleasure is significant on many levels. To understand how contemporary reading is developing, therefore, it is important to establish ways of finding valid and timely information about what people are choosing to read.

Part III: How We Assess It: Defining Evidence in a Period of Change

This brief account has offered a glimpse of the complexity of our contemporary reading world. Within the parentheses of the citations listed above lies another complex world of researchers

from a huge variety of institutional backgrounds, motivated by different goals, and drawing on an assortment of methodologies that may privilege currency in the cause of seizing a marketing opportunity, or focus on mining the big data of international assessment exercises, or draw on findings as a springboard for social action. A major challenge of working with such a multiplicity of sources is that just keeping up is a strenuous exercise. Finding ways to evaluate the trustworthiness of evidence from so many different informants is an equally enormous job.

There are, of course, many schools of thought on how to assess evidence, particularly in a field such as reading, where basing practice on evidence is held in great esteem. There is no room in this chapter to explore the many arguments in this arena. Instead, I turn to a small and simplified convenience sample, in order to address some of the issues in concrete, rather than abstract terms. My sample of two comprises, firstly, a long-term survey of reading behaviours, conducted by the National Endowment for the Arts in the United States, and, secondly, a very short-term and ephemeral global survey of app readership, conducted by a market research group called App Annie.

The International Literacy Association (now ILA; previously the International Reading Association – IRA) has produced a checklist listing five qualities that accrue to make evidence trustworthy; it must be objective, valid, reliable, systematic, and refereed. For the purposes of this chapter, I will focus on validity and reliability, because they raise the most interesting challenges for the kinds of research represented in this chapter. The IRA definition of “valid” is that the data “adequately represent the tasks that children need to accomplish to be successful readers” (International Reading Association, 2002, n.p.); the Association for Qualitative Research suggests that “validity ... refers to how well a scientific test or piece of research actually measures what it sets out to, or how well it reflects the reality it claims to represent” (www.aqr.org.uk/glossary/validity). The IRA says that evidence is “reliable” if “data will remain essentially unchanged if collected on a different day or by a different person” (2002, n.p.); similarly, the Association for Qualitative Research defines reliability as the “repeatability of a particular set of research findings; that is, how accurately they would be replicated in a second identical piece of research” (www.aqr.org.uk/glossary/reliability). But such desirable elements may be challenging to establish as these two case studies demonstrate; and their value is waning in the face of contemporary complexity.

Case #1: The Missing Readers in the NEA Surveys

How researchers define appropriate parameters for their research questions serves to frame the answers in constitutive and sometimes reductive ways. A classic example of how research limitations may define issues of “who is reading what” lies in reports from the American organization, the National Endowment for the Arts – NEA (2004, 2007, 2009, 2013, 2016). Employing a survey of public participation in the arts, conducted by the United States Census Bureau at periodic intervals, the NEA reports on a sample size of many thousands of individuals aged 18 and over. Each time, the survey asks respondents if, during the previous 12 months, they have read any novels, short stories, plays, or poetry in their leisure time (not for work or school). This question throws into relief the vagueness of the Pew survey (<http://newsbreaks.infotoday.com/Digest/Pew-Unveils-Latest-Survey-Results-on-Americans-Reading-Habits-123778.asp>), which simply tallies “books.” Such a very restrictive definition of literary reading, however, is highly fiction-oriented and excludes philosophy, history, biography, science writing, political analysis, essays, and other forms of nonfiction that may possess highly literary qualities, and that certainly represent categories of serious leisure reading; sports and hobbies are similarly barred from consideration, though they may elicit very dedicated reading activities. The NEA’s characterization of “literary reading” allows for “any print format, including the Internet” (2004, n.p.), but it does

not consider new forms of writing that might capitalize on the interactive affordances of online reading. The Internet counts only when it serves as a delivery mechanism for novels, short stories, plays, and poems.

The NEA report proves to be as slippery as most other research on what people read. The 2004 report warns that literary reading is declining drastically. The 2009 sequel describes “a decisive and unambiguous increase among virtually every group measured in this comprehensive national survey” (2009, n.p.). By 2013, the NEA is pessimistic again. Based on a survey of 35,735 American adults, they report only 47% reading at least one work of literature, as they define it. A short-form Basic Survey in 2016, reports a further drop to 43%, the lowest number in their entire reporting cycle (Ingraham, 2016).

The NEA findings and conclusions stirred substantial public and political debate in the United States, and it may be helpful to evaluate their work in terms of the evidence they offer. These reports would pass on four of the five criteria listed by the IRA, but it can be argued that the validity is limited because of the question mark over whether the data “adequately represent the tasks” of “successful readers.”

What are possible consequences of the NEA’s skew towards fictional categories? High on the list of potential implications are questions concerning gender. The 2013 report does not discuss whether that bias in favour of fictional materials might affect the numbers of male readers of “literature” (37%, compared to 56.1% of women), but it is a reasonable question to ask, given that the preference of boys and men for nonfiction is a well-known phenomenon, as I now clarify in a short but important digression. Available studies tend to draw on binary definitions of gender, but a more open set of categories would probably not substantially alter the significance of the pronounced differences that are manifest in many studies, though details might be more nuanced.

Research suggests that the male preference for reading nonfiction crosses all ages. For example, Sullivan (2009) says that:

boys often see nonfiction not as a vehicle for finding specific information but as a way to better understand the world around them, a way of acquiring the understanding of the world around them that they so desire and believe will help them to succeed. In short, they read nonfiction the way we expect children to read fiction.

(9)

Smith and Wilhelm (2002, 2006) confirm these proclivities among older adolescent boys, and Summers’ small study found the number of men preferring nonfiction to be almost double the number of women (2013, 247). Given the PISA-based findings (Chiu & McBride-Chang, 2006) that reading enjoyment ameliorates gender effects, the NEA questionnaire’s slant towards fiction takes on further significance.

And yet the NEA treats its fiction bias as something neutral. It is a salutary reminder that even when research methodology is exemplary, longitudinal information is scrupulously acquired, and samples are very large, the assumptions of the framing questions can limit the results. The facts presented by the NEA are “objective” within their limitations, but they are so selective that they mislead as much as they inform.

The decision to omit those who are reading for work or school also skews the results. Stebbins, in a study of the “committed reader” (2012), discusses the significance of reading for utility, for pleasure, and for fulfillment. This range of motivations may account for some of the gap – in surveys reported in the same month, September 2016 – between the NEA findings of 43% reading a work of literature and the Pew tally of 73% of Americans reading a book in the previous year. A committed reader need not be a literary reader. Stebbins draws on insights from two disciplinary fields: library and information studies and serious leisure studies. Perhaps this background accounts for his agnosticism about content, in contrast to the NEA’s strong focus on literariness.

The power of saying what gets to “count” as valid reading is a significant but often invisible force in discussions about reading at all levels, and is a factor in the fields of literary studies and education in particular. The idea that truly literate and cultured people invariably read fiction is well entrenched, in classrooms as well as in national organizations – though this emphasis is now challenged by the Common Core Curriculum in the United States. A fiction bias excludes many potential readers. A classroom emphasis on fiction also fosters the possibility that students are taught significantly less about the deep and/or critical reading of nonfiction than they need to know in order to function as contemporary citizens (Topping, Samuels, & Paul, 2008; White, 2011).

Case #2: App Annie and the Strengths and Perils of Short-Termism

As the NEA categories remind us, there is a cultural tendency to regard literature as relatively timeless. With much contemporary reading material, however, the issue of replicability of research becomes significant because of temporal limitations. The IRA definition of reliability is that data will remain unchanged if collected on a different day. In our contemporary world of shifting platforms and formats, that concept of reliability is more and more unrealistic, as my next example shows.

Patterns of contemporary reading behaviour are the subject of many different research approaches, and the motivations for such research are as varied as the methodologies. To be current in this territory is to trade in the ephemeral, and many active researchers in this area have short-term commercial aims in mind. For example, a business organization called App Annie surveys apps downloaded in April 2016 by active iPhone users and produces a top-ten list that features three different #1 titles in three different countries: the United States (Facebook), Japan (LINE), and the United Kingdom (WhatsApp Messenger) (App Annie, 2016). The same survey measures the top ten apps by growth in usage penetration between April 2015 and April 2016; again the #1 title is different in each of these countries, and also different from the three titles featuring in the first table (in the U.S., Facebook Messenger; in Japan, Yahoo! Japan Weather; and in the U.K., TripAdvisor).

With the timelines for app readership so short, information about usage that is up-to-date is also temporary. Any study that presents such data via peer review is likely to be obsolete before it even gets to press. Yet, any account of what people read that deals only with “permanent” content that can be relied on to stay constant throughout the publication time lag of refereed research simply does not offer a true picture of our contemporary situation, just as overly conservative definitions of literary reading restrict the broad utility of the NEA surveys.

In the current policy climate, particularly in the U.S. and the U.K., the “replicability” of research findings is important for legislators ruling on curriculum decisions. The App Annie findings indicate that many “what” questions are unlikely to be replicated even month to month. It is frequently the case that the most detailed information about shifting public reading behaviors comes from commercially motivated researchers, whose work is never refereed past the point of assessing its utility to the sponsor. With so many forms and products of current reporting to assess, it is arguable that we need some temporary and provisional standards for assessing reliability in the short-term, while we attempt to discern the larger patterns at work. For example, in the early 2010s it did seem as if e-reading was making unstoppable inroads into paper reading, but that trend has stalled; it is useful to observe this pattern, but an unavoidable and very basic conclusion is that we do not know how it will all work out.

One solution to this ongoing problem of large amounts of short-term data of differing provenance would be for like-minded researchers to establish an online clearinghouse for information about what people are currently reading, in paper, online, and app form. Background information

about the *bona fides* of the different commercial organizations supplying short-term data could also be incorporated. For reasons of space in this chapter, my IRA checklist of research evaluation tools is a simplistic one, but a more complex grid of quality checks would be relatively straightforward to establish. Such efforts would be more economical and more productive if conducted on a collaborative scale.

Such a clearinghouse could also provide context for the many surveys produced by research organizations such as Pew and the National Endowment for the Arts in the United States, Ofcom and the National Literacy Trust in the United Kingdom, MediaSmarts in Canada, and many other organizations, some of which are cited in this chapter. A trusted source for keeping up to date with contemporary reading shifts and mutations would be a huge help as researchers, educators, librarians, and others, struggle to attain some perspective on the fast-moving contemporary scene.

Part IV: How We Read What We Read in the 21st Century: Situated and Dedicated Contexts

A brief consideration of *how* we read today may aid our assessment of *what* we read. The concepts of “situated” reading and “dedicated” reading offer a useful distinction. These categories are not discrete and readers regularly move back and forth between them.

Situated reading is woven into daily life in fleeting and fragmented ways. In the middle of a conversation, someone will quickly google a relevant fact. As part of a social get-together, someone will message a photo to their friends. The live action of our daily affairs is frequently punctuated with brief mediated interludes. Digital technologies introduce portable interactivity in ways that inflect much daily living.

The impact of smartphones on what and how people read is difficult to overestimate. A 2015 Pew report says that 24% of American teens are online “almost constantly,” and 92% go online daily. Nearly three-quarters of American teens “have or have access to a smartphone.” Only 12% of teens aged 13 to 17 have no phone of any type. Pew reports that “African-American teens are the most likely of any group of teens to have a smartphone, with 85% having access to one, compared with 71% of both white and Hispanic teens” (Lenhart, 2015, n.p.). Young people who inherit parental phones are now more likely, by the year, to acquire a second-hand smartphone.

The World Bank (2016) provides international figures that indicate that cellphone use is not confined to the affluent West, but is globally distributed in surprising ways. Results are measured in terms of active mobile cellular subscriptions per 100 people. The highest number recorded (323 per 100 people) comes from Macao SAR, in China, and Hong Kong checks in at 234. A prosperous country like Canada (a latecomer to widespread cellphone use) records a score of only 81, while Vietnam, a country often perceived as developing, registers 147. The United States number is 110 and the United Kingdom is 124 (<http://data.worldbank.org/indicator/IT.CEL.SETS.P2>).

The extreme mobility and flexibility of smartphones feeds into a culture of situated reading. But such fragmentation of reading time is not neutral. No sliver of time is too small to be monetized. Google defines the “micro-moment” as “anytime you turn to an Internet-enabled device to find something, learn something, watch something or purchase something” (Selligent, n.d., n.p.). A real-life moment becomes open to commercial enhancement once it is mediated, for however brief a period.

These spontaneous task-driven engagements ... represent critical opportunities for brands and marketers alike. It is in these small, fragmented, and reflexive moments that impressions are formed and choices made. Understanding how to measure, manoeuvre, and master the micro-moment is mission critical for any brand or business looking to win customers in the digital age.

(Selligent, n.d., n.p.)

Situated literacy, with its almost seamless movement in and out of textual engagement, may thus be framed by its marketing potential; consequently, it presents an associated need for more critical perspectives about these transitory encounters. The ability to move in and out of contact with other people also represents a shift in the social framing of much reading.

In contrast, *dedicated reading* is more familiar. It involves a deliberate choice to engage with text in a more extended way. The event can feature a novel, or it may involve a complex information text. Alternatively, dedicated encounters may be multimodal – instead or as well – entailing a decision to binge-watch an entire television series on Netflix, or to commit to a protracted computer game and all its associated texts. It may involve a transmedia experience, in which a complete text is distributed across a number of platforms (Jenkins, 2007), or call for extensive movement between fictional and informational sources. Sometimes what starts out as a small example of situated literacy morphs to the status of an event, as one link leads to another, or a Twitter exchange takes on a life of its own. Sometimes a dedicated encounter is punctuated by situated exchanges of comment and/or critique.

One example of a gap between in-school and out-of-school literacies is summed up by the fact that many educational discourses privilege dedicated literacy. The distinction between the two kinds of engagement is at the heart of the ongoing dispute between two perceptions voiced by the lay public: “Kids today aren’t reading” versus “Kids today read and write more than they ever did.” Young people’s *situated reading* is obviously more extensive than it was even a decade ago. But most of the public discussion invoking a cultural crisis in reading is focused on a perceived decline in *dedicated reading*. I hope this chapter has shown that the overall situation is more complicated than either extreme of the popular argument.

Filling Gaps and Meeting Challenges

A radical instability in the cultural landscape of texts and formats has been normalized to the point of invisibility for many people. We download upgrades, we add a new platform or app, we pay less attention to an old one, we make incremental changes, and after a while, we forget that it wasn’t always like this – whatever “this” looks like at that moment.

In short, there is little point here in discussing the daily details of participation in particular forms of social media. Keith Oatley suggests a broader perspective may be more useful: “rather than thinking about implementation in paper and print as compared with electronic words on a computer screen, we should think of psychological functions” (2013, 179). To some degree, the comparison between situated and dedicated reading is a question of psychological function. Three further sub-headings may help refine our attention to major gaps in and challenges to our current understanding of contemporary reading choices.

Social Reading

The portability of reading and writing facilities now permits both activities to be slid into daily life in very small doses as part of ongoing social exchange, the epitome of situated reading. Many of the exchanges that develop through texting or Twitter or Snapchat may be described as low-level in terms of actual content, though their social value is high.

It is easy to see such situated reading as social. But dedicated reading also rides on a social network of writers, publishers, booksellers, and other readers (Nelles, 2013, 42). Digitization explicitly opens the way for “readers to participate in the debate themselves” in rather more direct ways (Hammond, 2016, 13). Digital reading may be less private, as we may see from, for example, Goodreads discussion forums, the Kindle’s group-underlining feature, Genius.com’s interface for crowd-sourced annotations of any text, SocialBook’s platform for threaded

conversations in the “margins” of digital books (see Hammond, 2016, 80). Social reading skews in favor of the public, but the whole concept of readers’ rights to privacy is suddenly the focus of urgent discussion after the March 2018 revelation of the Facebook and Cambridge Analytica misuse of reader data.

Reader exchanges on the platforms listed above may indeed deepen and enrich one’s individual thoughtful reading – or they may perhaps substitute for it, with people reading social commentary with more attention than they devote to the initiating text. In this case, as in so many others represented in this chapter, knowing more about *what* people are reading does not necessarily illuminate *how* their reception processes work. A sophisticated understanding of the role of social exchanges in today’s reading contexts would enormously improve our ability to draw on new social tools.

Deep Reading

A singular, extended intimacy with invented characters and settings, or with prolonged analysis of a serious nonfiction topic, represents the far end of a reading spectrum. The paper book, of course, survives. It is easy to associate dedicated reading with paper, but much sustained electronic reading is also a feature of our current culture, whether on single-use e-readers, or on phones, or tablets. We need to understand more about if and/or how the simple fact of digitization affects the solitary, private experience of what Wolf and Barzillai call deep reading – “the array of sophisticated processes that propel comprehension and that include inferential and deductive reasoning, analogical skills, critical analysis, reflection, and insight” (2009, 32). We are a long way from establishing a robust answer to that question. It is possible that the NEA’s category of “literature” is intended to serve as a proxy for this kind of deep reading.

We may also question whether deep reading needs be confined to print alone. New publishing options expand what was once a print space to include adaptations and reworkings in assorted media, background materials, fan contributions, and much, much more. Audiobooks may offer another form of deep experience.

Wolf, a scholar of the neuroscience of reading, expresses concern that, in response to the prevalence of situated reading in contemporary society, the great plasticity of our minds may lead us away from the contemplative achievements of deep reading towards a more fragmentary cognitive arrangement (Rosenwald, 2014; Wolf & Barzillai, 2009; Wolf & Gottwald, 2016). Wolf and her various colleagues have not addressed the issue of listening to a book, nor commented on whether a reading that crosses many media boundaries should be classified as deep or shallow. There are also many questions about whether it is possible to conduct a deep reading experience across a range of related websites. To establish a satisfactory account of the parameters of successful deep reading in current times would be to plug a crucial gap in our understanding.

Critical Reading

The fate of critical reading in a world of situated textual encounters is also not clear. Alan Luke says, “Critical literacy has an explicit aim of the critique and transformation of dominant ideologies, cultures and economies, institutions, and political systems” (2014, 22).

It seems likely that our collective failure to take situated reading seriously leads to important gaps, both in our larger understanding and in our specific capacity to consider the need for critical literacy in this arena. Much situated information comes with the stamp of personal insider authority. Are people less likely to critique (say) a political observation masquerading as factual if it comes (say) from a Facebook friend? To what extent do contemporary readers overvalue the “eyewitness” vividness of personal insights, and underestimate the need to fact-check the data we

glean from our friends and acquaintances on social media? Marketers have established that a personal recommendation is the surest way to make a sale to a potential customer, and have established market relations with private individuals posting online. The need for critical scrutiny of what our friends are telling us is counter-intuitive to many readers. We need a multifaceted awareness of the shape and potential of a contemporary critical literacy.

At its self-taught and instinctual extreme, some information-gathering behavior today may be described as “feral” rather than sceptical or critical (Mackey, 2008, 5). “Snackable content” is easily swallowed whole. It is important to develop a critical stance towards our information-seeking “micro-moments” and how they may be shaped by marketing imperatives, and to reflect on the warrant of the “facts” presented on social media. Sophisticated media literacy demands attention to small moments of textual exchange as well as to larger questions.

Conclusions

Answers to the question of what people are reading (on what format) and why (and how), can only be expressed provisionally as we move through an enormous change in technological and cultural affordances, frequently framed by commercial motivations. Readers, in both situated and dedicated contexts, are dealing with new challenges in the social and critical frameworks they move through; and the shape of deep reading needs to be clarified in productive ways to take account of new text forms and networks. Information about reading choices comes and goes at a dizzying rate; establishing a central clearinghouse where data can be readily found and intelligently evaluated would make a big difference to our ability to be as nimble as we need to be.

Markers to watch in the short-term future, as seen from mid-2018, include the large-scale findings about international reading attitudes that may be uncovered by PISA’s 2018 special surveys, the ripples from the Facebook scandal, the impact of the Common Core on attitudes towards nonfiction, and the rise or subsidence of e-reading. No doubt many new issues will also arise. As we take account of them, we must continue to monitor how critical, social, and deep reading play out in both situated and dedicated reading conditions, in the ever-shifting textual universes of the 21st century.

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